possible source of knowledge, then merely listening to the insights gained from someone else's lived experience cannot impart these insights to me.

The only way to have a large-scale political conversation among diverse groups of people is if people can gain some understanding of issues that they have never experienced first hand. In a large polity, it is a crucial role of the education system and the media to inform people about things they have never faced themselves. If there is no education system or media platform to perform this role, no meaningful large-scale conversations can take place.

In a small Neolithic town of a few thousand inhabitants people might sometimes have been afraid to say what they thought, or might have refused to listen to their rivals, but it was relatively easy to satisfy the more fundamental technical preconditions for meaningful discourse. First, people lived in proximity to one another, so they could easily meet most other community members and hear their voices. Second, everybody had intimate knowledge of the dangers and opportunities that the town faced. If an enemy war party approached, everyone could see it. If the river flooded the fields, everyone witnessed the economic effects. When people talked about war and hunger, they knew what they were saying.

In the fourth century BCE, the city-state of Rome was still small enough to allow a large percentage of its citizens to congregate in the Forum in times of emergency, listen to respected leaders and voice their personal views on the matter at hand. When in 390 BCE Gallic invaders attacked Rome, almost everyone lost a relative in the defeat at the Battle of the Allia and lost property when the victorious Gauls then sacked Rome. The desperate Romans appointed Marcus Camillus as dictator. In Rome, the dictator was a public official appointed in times of emergency who had unlimited powers but only for a short predetermined period, following which he was held accountable for his actions. After Camillus led the Romans to victory, everybody could see that the emergency was over, and Camillus stepped down.[27]

In contrast, by the third century CE, the Roman Empire had a population of between sixty and seventy-five million people,[28] spread over five million square kilometres.[29] Rome lacked mass communication technology like radio or daily newspapers. Only 10–20 per cent of adults had reading skills,[30] and there was no organised education system that could inform